

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES
MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES
ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING
FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES
STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

BENCHMARK® INTERNATIONAL

MIDDLE MARKET

QUARTERLY INDUSTRY REPORT | Q4 2026

BUSINESS SERVICES

Mergers and acquisitions across commercial, professional, and human capital services.

WHAT'S INCLUDED

01	INSIGHTS	Key trends, perspectives on five sectors, what we are reading, and a feature on fire and life safety
02	INDUSTRY ACTIVITY	Client spotlight, recent transactions, listed-company valuation, earnings, economic trends, and active buyers
03	CONNECT WITH US	Our team and Benchmark International

OCTOBER 2026 | JARED HARDIN, MANAGING DIRECTOR

01

Insights

KEY INSIGHTS

01 Inspection work draws the deepest buyer pool
Pye-Barker completed 22 acquisitions in the first half of 2026, after 57 in 2025. Acquirers compete hardest for contracted inspection and service work.

02 Costlier debt puts a premium on proof
Debt on platform acquisitions fell to 2.9x EBITDA from 3.4x, and the Federal Reserve raised its target range on September 16. Documented earnings and contracted customers now command the premium.

03 Engineering buyers pay for people and backlog
Bernhard Capital agreed to buy Bowman at a 58% premium, and 88% of engineering firms report open positions. Licensed staff and a year of funded backlog set the price.

04 Prepared sellers still draw several offers
Completed middle-market deals averaged 7.0x EBITDA in the second quarter, and 87% of sales above $5 million drew three or more offers. Keep every client below a fifth of revenue.



Key Trends in Business Services

Six developments are shaping demand, pricing, and deal activity across the five sectors as the fourth quarter begins.

Inspection-driven revenue draws the most active buyers — 22

Pye-Barker Fire & Safety completed 22 acquisitions in the first half of 2026 after 57 in 2025 (Pye-Barker). APi Group grew 10.1% organically in the second quarter and reported a backlog above $5 billion (APi Group).

Acquirers compete most actively for contracted inspection and service work.

Financing became more expensive in the third quarter — 4.99%

The Federal Reserve raised its target range to 3.75% to 4.00% on September 16 (Federal Reserve), and the 10-year Treasury yield averaged 4.99% in September (FRED). Debt on platform acquisitions fell to 2.9x EBITDA from 3.4x (GF Data via ACG).

Costlier debt puts a premium on documented earnings and contracted customers.

Engineering backlogs run a year deep and licensed staff are scarce — 88%

The median engineering firm holds 12 months of backlog, and 88% of firms report open positions (ACEC). Bernhard Capital agreed to buy Bowman for about $1.0 billion of enterprise value, a 58% premium (Bowman).

Buyers of engineering firms are paying for licensed staff and funded backlog.

Softer insurance pricing has slowed broker organic growth — –2%

Commercial premiums fell 2% on average in the second quarter, with property down 6.3% (Insurance Journal). Aon agreed to buy USI for $17 billion in cash (Insurance Journal, September 21).

Small commercial and casualty accounts are seeing the least pricing pressure.

Staffing revenue is growing for the first time in three years — +5%

Median staffing revenue grew 5% in August, the highest reading since late 2022 (Staffing Industry Analysts). Temporary help employment remains 21% below its March 2022 peak (BLS via FRED).

Skilled trades, engineering, and healthcare placements are drawing acquirers.

Advertising is growing while AI changes what agencies sell — +9.6%

US advertising revenue is forecast to grow 9.6% in 2026 (MediaPost). Marketing budgets hold at 7.8% of company revenue, with 15.3% of those budgets directed to AI (Marketing Dive).

Retained clients, first-party data, and measurable outcomes hold their value.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR OWNERS

Buyers pay most readily for revenue that repeats under contract. Completed middle-market transactions averaged 7.0x EBITDA in the second quarter (GF Data via ACG), the median multiple on sales of $5 million to $50 million reached 5.8x (IBBA and M&A Source), and 87% of sales above $5 million drew three or more offers (IBBA and M&A Source release).

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

Figures are the latest published as of October 7, 2026, and each is linked to its source. The 10-year Treasury figure is the monthly average for September 2026. EBITDA is earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization.

Perspectives on Five Sectors

Each sector has its own buyers and drivers, and the same five tests decide how a buyer values a business in any of them.

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES



Contracted, inspection-driven revenue is drawing the most active consolidators.

MARKET SIZE AND GROWTH

Recurring monthly revenue at the 100 largest security dealers rose 7% to $740 million in 2025 (SDM), and SGS grew 5.6% organically in the first half (SGS).

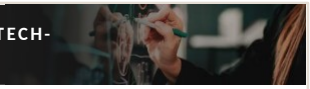
ACTIVE BUYERS

Pye-Barker, APi Group, AI Fire, and Cintas in fire and safety; Allied Universal in guarding; DEX Imaging and UBEO in office technology; SGS and TIC Solutions in testing.

WHAT BUYERS REWARD

Inspection, monitoring, and service contracts that renew each year, and licenses held by the company.

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES



Advertising demand is strong, and buyers want specialists with data or a vertical focus.

MARKET SIZE AND GROWTH

US internet advertising revenue reached $294.6 billion in 2025, up 13.9% (IAB and PwC), and promotional products sales reached a record $27.7 billion (ASI).

ACTIVE BUYERS

Sponsor-backed agency platforms such as OneMagnify, Power Digital, and Wpromote; Publicis and Havas; Accenture and Cognizant; HALO and Proforma in promotional products.

WHAT BUYERS REWARD

Retained client relationships, depth in one vertical, proprietary data, and a team beyond the founder.

ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING



Backlogs run a year deep, and private capital is paying for licensed talent.

MARKET SIZE AND GROWTH

The 500 largest design firms reported $158.7 billion of revenue, up 7.4% (ENR), and 447 transactions were announced among design and construction firms in 2025 (PSMJ).

ACTIVE BUYERS

Bernhard Capital Partners; Ardurra, owned by Littlejohn & Co.; Salas O'Brien; SAM Companies; Pape-Dawson; J.S. Held in forensic engineering.

WHAT BUYERS REWARD

Funded backlog of a year or more, licensed staff, and a second generation of principals.

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES



Softer premiums are slowing organic growth while the largest brokers keep buying.

MARKET SIZE AND GROWTH

Managing general agents wrote $108.7 billion of premium in 2025, up 17.8% (Risk & Insurance), and advisory firm sales moved $342.9 billion of client assets in the first half (WealthManagement.com).

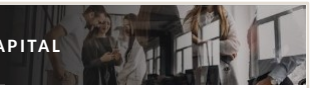
ACTIVE BUYERS

Aon, Gallagher, Inszone, EPIC, King Risk Partners, and World Insurance Associates in brokerage; Hightower and Mercer Advisors in wealth.

WHAT BUYERS REWARD

Recurring commissions and fees with high retention, and producers under contract beyond the owner.

STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL



Staffing revenue is growing for the first time in three years, led by skilled work.

MARKET SIZE AND GROWTH

US staffing sales were $113.5 billion in 2025, down 8.5% (ASA), and industrial staffing revenue is now forecast to grow 7% in 2026 (Staffing Industry Analysts).

ACTIVE BUYERS

Korn Ferry, Aerotek, ALKU, CHG Healthcare, and Airswift, with sponsor-backed specialists in skilled trades and engineering.

WHAT BUYERS REWARD

Specialty placements, gross margin held through the downturn, and direct client relationships.

ACROSS ALL FIVE SECTORS

Five tests buyers apply

1. **Revenue that repeats under contract**
   Service agreements, retainers, and renewals.
2. **Licensed, certified, or tenured people**
   Credentials held by the company.
3. **Management beyond the owner**
   Leaders who hold the client relationships.
4. **No client above a fifth of revenue**
   One dominant account lowers the price.
5. **Margins that held through the downturn**
   Proof that pricing and staffing can adjust.

Active buyers are drawn from transactions announced between October 2025 and October 2026. Company names are the property of their owners and are shown for identification.

What We're Reading

Six primary sources and trade reports from the third quarter, with the reason each one matters to an owner.

INDUSTRY READING

ACEC RESEARCH INSTITUTE — August 27, 2026

Engineering firms hold a year of work and expect a slower economy

The third-quarter survey of engineering firms recorded a median backlog of 12 months, with the strongest sentiment in data centers and in water and wastewater. The same firms put the odds of a recession within six months at 41%, and 88% reported open positions.

> **Our read.** Backlog and a bench of licensed engineers are the first two facts a buyer will test.

READ HERE

STAFFING INDUSTRY ANALYSTS — September 29, 2026

Staffing revenue grows 5% at the median, the best reading since 2022

The August Pulse Survey of 128 staffing firms recorded median revenue growth of 5% from a year earlier. Engineering staffing led at 10% and industrial staffing followed at 8%, after three years in which industry revenue declined.

> **Our read.** The recovery is strongest in the skilled categories where this year's acquisitions are concentrated.

READ HERE

INSURANCE JOURNAL — August 20, 2026

Commercial premiums fall 2% as property pricing softens

The Council of Insurance Agents & Brokers recorded an average premium decline of 2% in the second quarter. Large accounts fell 3.7% and small accounts 0.5%. Commercial property fell 6.3% while umbrella and commercial auto continued to rise.

> **Our read.** Account size and line of business now explain most of the difference in agency growth.

READ HERE

ECONOMY AND DEAL MARKET

REUTERS — October 1, 2026

Global deal value falls 41% in the third quarter

Announced global M&A fell to $993 billion in the third quarter, the first quarter under $1 trillion since mid-2025, after a record first half. The report attributes the decline to rising borrowing costs.

> **Our read.** The slowdown is concentrated in the largest transactions. Add-on purchases by existing platforms made up about three-quarters of second-quarter buyouts (PitchBook).

READ HERE

FEDERAL RESERVE — September 16, 2026

The Federal Open Market Committee raises its target range

The committee raised the target range for the federal funds rate by 25 basis points to 3.75% to 4.00% and stated that inflation remains elevated. Senior debt on middle-market acquisitions was already priced at 7.8% in the second quarter.

> **Our read.** Lenders are advancing less debt against each dollar of earnings, at 2.9x EBITDA on platform deals (GF Data via ACG).

READ HERE

IBBA AND M&A SOURCE — Market Pulse, second quarter 2026

Smaller transactions reach their highest multiple since early 2022

The quarterly survey of business brokers and M&A advisors put the median multiple on sales of $5 million to $50 million at 5.8x EBITDA, up from 5.5x. Sellers received 83% to 92% of the price in cash at closing.

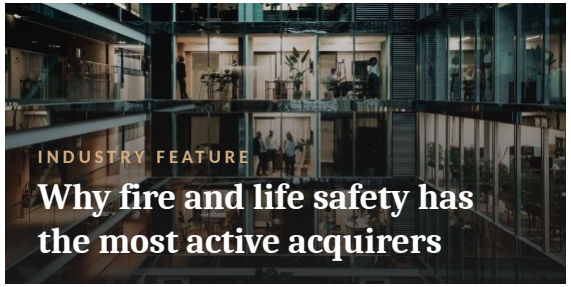
> **Our read.** Competition for well-prepared businesses is intact, with three or more offers on 87% of sales above $5 million (survey release).

READ HERE

Each summary restates the source in our own words and links to it, and each heading is our own description of the piece.

Feature: Fire and Life Safety

Inspection and service revenue explains why fire protection and security companies have the most active acquirers in business services.



INDUSTRY FEATURE

Why fire and life safety has the most active acquirers

Pye-Barker alone bought 79 fire and security companies in the 18 months to June 2026, and APi Group, Sciens Building Solutions, and AI Fire are buying alongside it. Three features of the work explain the interest.

1 **The work is contracted or mandated**
Inspection, testing, and monitoring repeat on a schedule, so the revenue continues when new construction slows.

2 **Each acquired branch adds density**
A buyer that already runs routes in a region can serve an acquired book of accounts with the technicians it has.

3 **Inspection leads the customer relationship**
APi bought CertaSite, with about $90 million of revenue, because the business leads with inspections and earns repair and service work from them.

22
Pye-Barker acquisitions in the first half of 2026, after 57 in 2025 (Pye-Barker; Security Systems News)

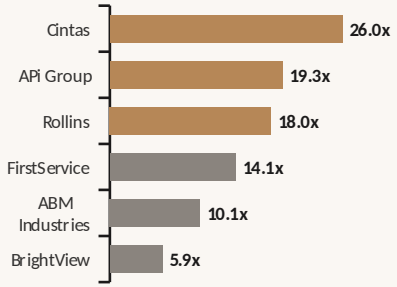
10.1%
APi Group organic revenue growth in the second quarter, with backlog above $5 billion (APi Group)

60%+
Share of revenue APi aims to earn from inspection and service (APi Group, December 10, 2025)

$740M
Recurring monthly revenue of the 100 largest security dealers in 2025, up 7% (SDM)

Route-based and inspection-driven companies trade above labor-intensive ones

Enterprise value to trailing EBITDA of six listed services companies. Source: StockAnalysis



Cintas and Rollins run recurring service routes, and APi Group is built around inspection and service. ABM and BrightView depend more heavily on labor hours.

RECENT FIRE AND SECURITY TRANSACTIONS

BUYER	TARGET (LINKED)	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	DATE
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	Union AlarmTronic	Family-owned alarm, access control, and video company, New Jersey	Sep 2026
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	Suppression Systems, Inc.	Fire suppression, Pacific Northwest	Aug 2026
Allied Universal	Aegis Protective Services and Admiral Security Services	Guard services and security technology	Jun 2026
Sciens Building Solutions	Southern Fire Control	Fire protection	Jan 2026
APi Group	CertaSite	Fire and life safety inspection, Midwest	Dec 2025

Purchase prices were not disclosed for these transactions. Benchmark International's own fire and life safety sales appear in the client spotlight in the next section.

WHAT A BUYER WILL ASK

An owner in this field should expect to be asked what share of revenue comes from inspection, monitoring, and service agreements, whether the licenses are held by the company or by the owner personally, and how long the technicians have been with the business.

Listed multiples were retrieved on October 7, 2026, and use reported EBITDA. Rollins is a pest control company and is included as a route-based comparison. Company names are the property of their owners.

02

Industry Activity

- Client spotlight
- Select recent M&A transactions
- Benchmark International transactions
- Public companies: valuation and operating metrics
- Earnings and commentary
- Economic trends
- Select market participants



Client Spotlight: Three Fire and Life Safety Sales

Benchmark International advised the owners of three fire protection businesses that were bought by operating companies already in the field.

FPS Technologies, Inc. ACQUIRED BY Cintas — Ready for the Workday

FPS Technologies and Cintas

BUSINESS OVERVIEW

FPS Technologies designs, installs, and maintains fire protection and safety systems from Oklahoma City and provides emergency service around the clock.

THE BUYER

Cintas is a listed company that serves more than one million business customers over approximately 12,500 local routes (Cintas annual report).

WHAT THE BUYER ADDED

A regional book of recurring fire system inspection and maintenance work.

Read the announcement

FST Fire Systems Technology Corp. ACQUIRED BY AI FIRE

Fire Systems Technology and AI Fire

BUSINESS OVERVIEW

Fire Systems Technology is a full-service fire sprinkler contractor in Arkansas that installs, inspects, maintains, and renovates systems.

THE BUYER

AI Fire is a fire and life safety platform backed by private equity that has been adding regional contractors.

WHAT THE BUYER ADDED

Sprinkler installation and inspection capacity in Arkansas.

Read the announcement

HIGH TECH SOLUTIONS SYSTEMS GROUP ACQUIRED BY AI FIRE

High Tech Solutions and AI Fire

BUSINESS OVERVIEW

High Tech Solutions - Systems Group designs, installs, and services special systems for customers in Montana and Wyoming.

THE BUYER

AI Fire made this purchase in addition to its acquisition of Fire Systems Technology.

WHAT THE BUYER ADDED

Special systems capability and a position in Montana and Wyoming.

Read the announcement



WHAT THE THREE SALES HAD IN COMMON

Service alongside installation

Each business maintained, inspected, or serviced the systems it installed, which gave the buyer continuing work with the same customers.

A defined home region

Oklahoma City, Arkansas, and Montana and Wyoming each gave the buyer a territory to add to its existing coverage.

A buyer already in the field

Cintas and AI Fire both operate fire protection businesses, so each purchase extended a platform that was already in place.

Business descriptions are taken from the announcements published on benchmarkintl.com, which are linked from each card. Transaction values are not disclosed. Company names and marks are the property of their owners.

Select Recent Business Services M&A Transactions

One transaction from each sector and one with disclosed economics, announced between June and October 2026.

SEPTEMBER 2026 — COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES

UNION ALARMTRONIC — ACQUIRED BY — PYE-BARKER FIRE & SAFETY

Pye-Barker adds a family-owned alarm company in New Jersey

Union AlarmTronic provides alarm, access control, and video systems. The purchase follows 22 acquisitions by Pye-Barker in the first half of 2026 and 57 in 2025 across fire and security (Pye-Barker).

WHAT IT SHOWS Family-owned alarm and fire companies with monitoring revenue continue to find a buyer quickly.

OCTOBER 2026 — MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES

EAST BEACH SPECIALTIES — ACQUIRED BY — ZEBRA MARKETING

Zebra Marketing agrees to acquire East Beach Specialties

East Beach Specialties is a promotional products distributor on the Mississippi Gulf Coast (ASI). Distributor sales grew 2.5% in the second quarter, and firms under $1 million of revenue were flat (ASI Central).

WHAT IT SHOWS Scale is separating promotional products distributors, and smaller firms are joining larger ones.

AUGUST 2026 — ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING

BOWMAN CONSULTING GROUP — ACQUIRED BY — BERNHARD CAPITAL PARTNERS

Bernhard Capital agrees to buy Bowman for about $1.0 billion

Bowman is a founder-led engineering firm with more than 2,500 employees and a backlog of $658.7 million, up 50.3% (Bowman results). The offer of $43.00 per share is a 58% premium to the prior close (Bowman).

WHAT IT SHOWS Private capital is paying for licensed staff and funded backlog.

AUGUST 2026 — FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES

HARRIS INSURANCE SERVICES — ACQUIRED BY — INSZONE INSURANCE SERVICES

Inszone acquires a three-generation agency in Tulsa

Harris Insurance Services was founded in 1925 in West Tulsa, Oklahoma (Insurance Business). King Risk Partners, EPIC, and World Insurance Associates each bought a long-established agency in the weeks that followed (Insurance Journal).

WHAT IT SHOWS Multi-generation agencies are selling to consolidators while premium rates soften.

SEPTEMBER 2026 — STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

LABORWORX — ACQUIRED BY — VERIWORKS

VeriWorks enters data center construction staffing

LaborWorx supplies skilled trades for data center construction (Staffing Industry Analysts). In September, the 2026 forecast for industrial staffing revenue was raised to 7% growth from 1% (SIA forecast).

WHAT IT SHOWS Skilled trades tied to data center, power, and factory construction are drawing buyers.

JUNE 2026 — STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

AMS — ACQUIRED BY — KORN FERRY

Korn Ferry agrees to buy AMS at about 11 times EBITDA

The enterprise value of £850 million, roughly $1.1 billion, compares with about $650 million of fee revenue and about $100 million of run-rate adjusted EBITDA (Korn Ferry).

WHAT IT SHOWS Long-term outsourcing contracts earned a multiple in line with the 10.8x median of far larger listed staffing companies.

Transaction values are as reported by the linked source. The listed staffing median is on the valuation page of this brief. Company names are the property of their owners. Transactions advised by Benchmark International follow on the next page.

Benchmark International's Business Services Transactions

Marketing and sales services lead with 23 closed transactions, commercial and facility services follow with 21, and most buyers were operating companies.

TRAILING 24 MONTHS

67

transactions closed in these five sectors

142

further engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026, of which 69 are on the market

44

named sellers, more than half of them bought by a company in their own or an adjacent field

Ranked the leading privately owned sell-side M&A advisor in the world in PitchBook's Q2 2026 Global League Tables (Benchmark International).

FPS TECHNOLOGIES, INC.

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

CINTAS READY FOR THE WORKDAY

Fire protection and safety systems design, installation, and service

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY

FST FIRE SYSTEMS TECHNOLOGY, INC.

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

AI FIRE

Full-service fire sprinkler contractor, Arkansas

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY

PACIFIC

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

CRESSWELL VENTURES

Armed and unarmed security services

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY

BRIGGS ENGINEERING & TESTING

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

PHENNA GROUP

Inspection, testing, and quality control engineering

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY

Telmark SALES SOLUTIONS, INC.

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

Sentinel CAPITAL PARTNERS

Consumer packaged goods sales brokerage, sold to Sentinel's Market Performance Group

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED

MARTIANCRAFT

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

WALNUT CAPITAL PARTNERS

Software design and development agency

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED

SNAILWORKS Direct Mail Insights & Solutions

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

Beacon

Mail-tracking software for direct mailers

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED

TSM TOTAL SALES & MARKETING

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

Retail Rex CAPITAL

Promotional products and marketing services

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED

SJB GROUP

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

SURVEYING AND MAPPING (SAM)

Civil engineering firm, Baton Rouge, Louisiana

ENGINEERING & ARCHITECTURE

ENGINEERED BUILDING SYSTEMS

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

RTM ENGINEERING CONSULTANTS

Mechanical, electrical, and plumbing engineering, Northern Kentucky

ENGINEERING & ARCHITECTURE

ALTAIR ASSOCIATES

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

CENTRI BUSINESS CONSULTING

Underwriting and claims review for insurers and reinsurers

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE

MOKAVIA AEROSPACE

HAS BEEN ACQUIRED BY

HI-TEK

Aerospace engineering and technical contract staffing

STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

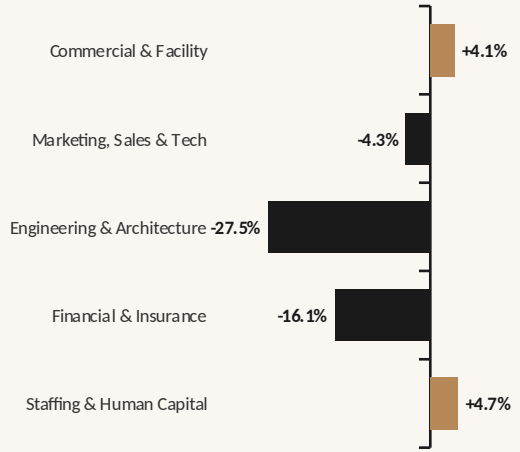
Each tile links to the announcement on benchmarkintl.com. Twelve of the 44 named transactions are shown. Transactions closed in the 24 months to September 2026. Engagements in progress are shown in aggregate. Company names and marks are the property of their owners.

Public Companies: Valuation

Listed multiples are lower than a year ago in all five sectors, and each sector trades below its three-year median.

Share price change, past 52 weeks

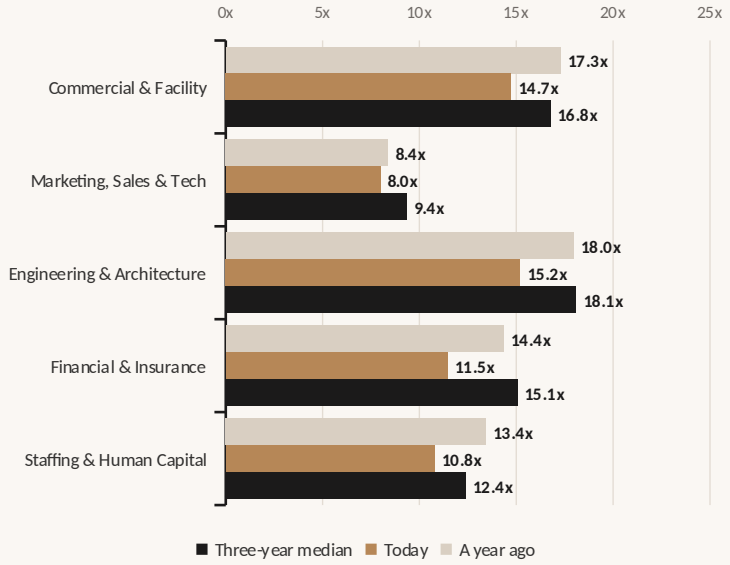
Median of the listed companies in each sector



Shares rose over the year at 6 of 11 commercial and facility, 3 of 9 marketing, 1 of 8 engineering, 2 of 7 financial and insurance, and 7 of 10 staffing companies.

Enterprise value to trailing EBITDA

Median multiple a year ago, today, and over three years, same companies at each point



26 of the 36 companies trade below their own three-year median multiple.

PRIVATE-DEAL REFERENCE POINTS

7.0x

Average for completed middle-market transactions in all industries, second quarter of 2026 (GF Data via ACG)

5.8x

Median for transactions of $5 million to $50 million in all industries, second quarter of 2026 (IBBA and M&A Source)

4.0x

Median for transactions of $2 million to $5 million in the same survey

Listed multiples describe companies many times larger than a founder-owned business.

LISTED COMPANIES IN EACH PEER GROUP, WITH ENTERPRISE VALUE TO TRAILING EBITDA

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY

Cintas **26.0x** | APi Group **19.3x** | UL Solutions **18.2x** | Rollins **18.0x** | SGS **15.4x** | FirstService **14.1x** | Intertek **13.0x** | Mistras Group **10.5x** | Bureau Veritas **10.4x** | ABM Industries **10.1x** | BrightView **5.9x** | Eurofins **n/m**

MARKETING, SALES & TECH

Stagwell **11.3x** | 4imprint **10.3x** | Daktronics **9.0x** | Accenture **8.2x** | Omnicom **7.7x** | Cognizant **6.7x** | Advantage Solutions **5.8x** | Dentsu **4.5x** | Publicis **n/m** | WPP **n/m**

ENGINEERING & ARCHITECTURE

Bowman Consulting **21.8x** | Jacobs **18.0x** | Willdan Group **16.1x** | Tetra Tech **14.3x** | TIC Solutions **13.4x** | Stantec **13.0x** | AECOM **10.7x** | WSP Global **n/m**

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE

Ryan Specialty **14.6x** | Marsh McLennan **13.2x** | Aon **12.4x** | WTW **11.4x** | Crawford **9.9x** | Brown & Brown **9.6x** | Gallagher **n/m** | Baldwin **n/m**

STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

Kforce **17.9x** | TriNet **13.1x** | Barrett (BBSI) **12.2x** | Randstad **10.8x** | ManpowerGroup **9.1x** | Korn Ferry **8.8x** | AMN Healthcare **5.7x** | TrueBlue **n/m** | Robert Half **n/m** | Insperity **n/m**

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

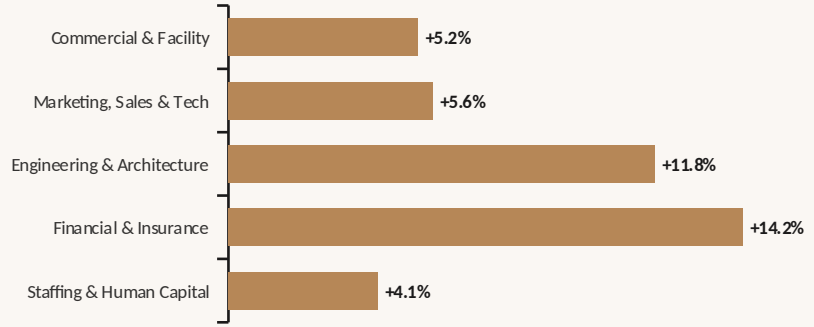
Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026, with share prices dated September 15 to October 7. Multiples use reported EBITDA. The chart covers the 36 companies with a current multiple under 50x, a year-ago multiple, and quarter-end history. The mark n/m identifies 9 companies whose multiple is above 50x, unavailable, or inconsistent on the source.

Public Companies: Operating and Valuation Metrics

Insurance brokers earn the widest margins and the highest revenue multiples, and staffing companies earn the narrowest.

Revenue growth, trailing twelve months

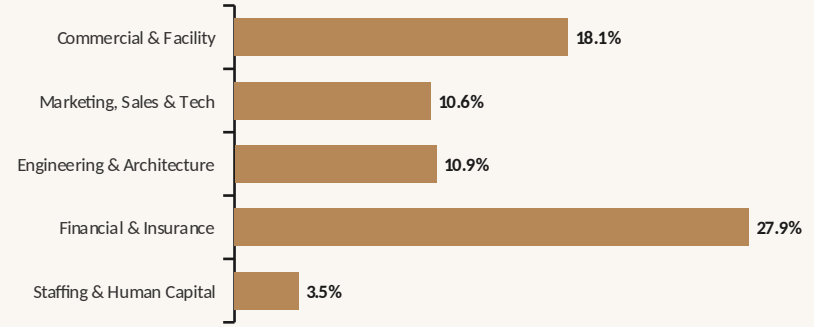
Median by sector; growth includes acquisitions



Financial and insurance growth reflects large acquisitions by the listed brokers, and engineering growth is supported by backlog.

EBITDA margin, trailing twelve months

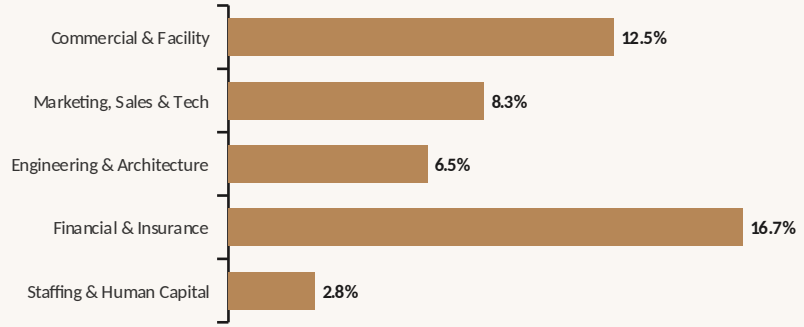
Median by sector, on reported EBITDA



Insurance brokerage earns the widest margin, and staffing earns the narrowest because most of its revenue passes through to payroll.

Free cash flow margin, trailing twelve months

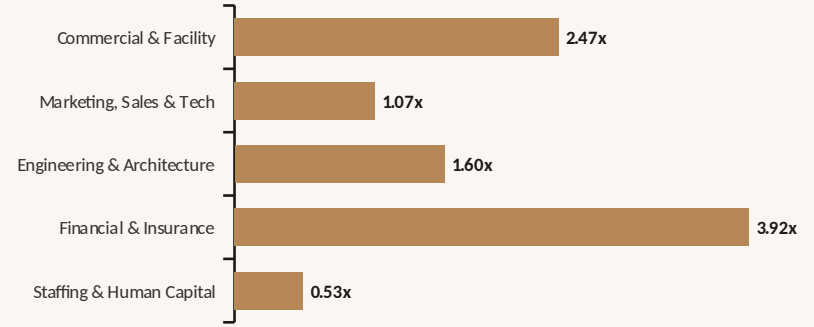
Median by sector



Commercial and facility services converts more revenue to cash than engineering or marketing services.

Enterprise value to trailing revenue

Median by sector



Revenue multiples follow margin, which is why an owner should compare a business with its own sector.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

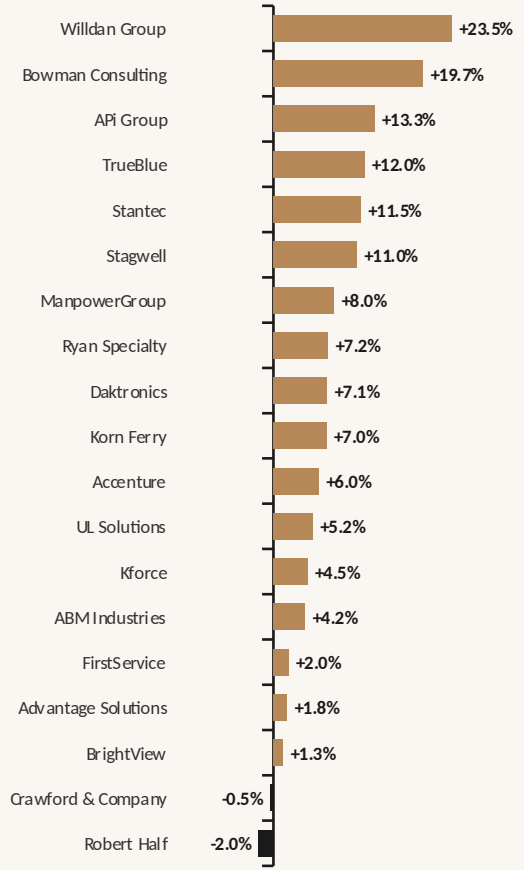
Source: StockAnalysis, retrieved October 7, 2026. Medians cover every listed company in each sector with a published figure, between 7 and 12 companies a sector. Trailing periods end between December 2025 and August 2026. EBITDA is as reported and is lower than the adjusted EBITDA companies present.

Earnings and Commentary

Engineering firms grew fastest, APi Group held double-digit growth, and four of the five staffing firms shown grew.

Revenue growth, latest reported quarter

Year over year, as stated in each earnings release; quarters ended June to August 2026



CONTRACTED AND INSPECTION-DRIVEN SERVICES

Russ Becker, President and Chief Executive Officer, APi Group

Credited inspection, service, and monitoring revenue, together with healthy project work, for double-digit organic growth, and pointed to a record backlog above $5 billion.

Scott Salmirs, President and Chief Executive Officer, ABM Industries

Said aviation and manufacturing and distribution led organic growth, and that deferred projects in the technical solutions business are expected to ramp in the fourth quarter.

Jennifer Scanlon, President and CEO, UL Solutions

Described record revenue, strong cash flow, and wider margins, and said the company is well positioned for the second half of 2026.

Scott Patterson, Chief Executive Officer, FirstService

Said profitability met expectations while macroeconomic headwinds held back organic growth.

READ-THROUGH

Inspection and service revenue is carrying growth while customers defer discretionary projects.

ENGINEERING AND ENERGY DEMAND

Gord Johnston, President and CEO, Stantec

Said a record backlog of $9.2 billion supports stronger activity in the second half and keeps the company on track for its 2026 targets.

Mike Bieber, President and Chief Executive Officer, Willdan Group

Linked growth to strong demand for energy work as customers spend to serve rising electricity load and to improve grid reliability.

Gary Bowman, founder and CEO, Bowman Consulting

Said demand is healthy across the firm's markets, that recent wins open the way to larger infrastructure assignments and that backlog reached $659 million.

Roger Argus, Chief Executive Officer, Tetra Tech

Attributed a strong quarter mainly to US federal and international markets, each of which grew at a double-digit rate.

READ-THROUGH

Power, water, and infrastructure work is filling backlogs, and buyers are paying for the licensed staff who deliver it.

HIRING AND CLIENT BUDGETS

Jonas Prising, Chair and CEO, ManpowerGroup

Said revenue beat expectations as demand improved, with very strong growth in the Manpower brand and better trends in the firm's professional and outsourcing businesses.

Joseph J. Liberatore, President and CEO, Kforce

Said clients that are wary of adding permanent headcount are turning to flexible talent for their technology initiatives.

Dave Peacock, CEO, Advantage Solutions

Said clients favor programs with measurable returns, with demand accelerating in experiential services and a slower recovery in branded services.

M. Keith Waddell, president and chief executive officer, Robert Half

Said hiring demand keeps improving and that market conditions are becoming more supportive.

READ-THROUGH

Staffing demand is returning, and marketing clients are concentrating spend where results can be measured.

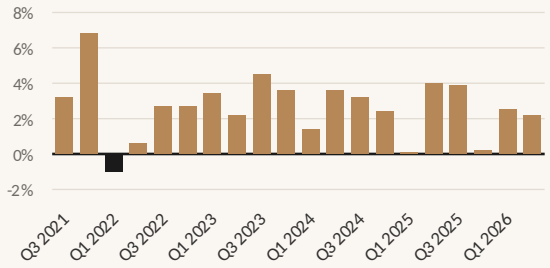
Figures are from each earnings release, linked from the company name. Commentary is summarized in our own words. Stantec and Willdan are on net revenue, Korn Ferry is on fee revenue, and Crawford is computed from stated revenue. Omnicom, Tetra Tech, and Baldwin state no comparable change and are not charted.

Economic Trends

Growth is positive, hiring has slowed, long-term yields are higher than a year ago and engineering employment keeps rising.

Real GDP growth

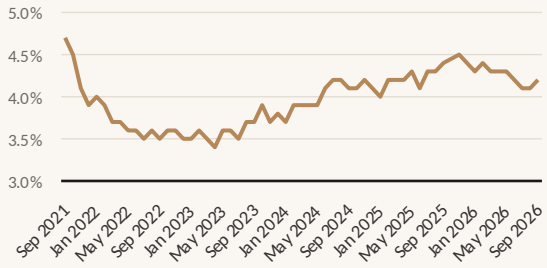
Quarterly change at a seasonally adjusted annual rate. Source: Bureau of Economic Analysis via FRED



The economy grew at a 2.2% annual rate in the second quarter of 2026 after 2.5% in the first.

Unemployment rate

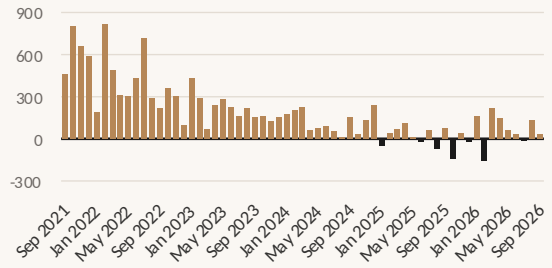
Seasonally adjusted. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics via FRED



Unemployment stood at 4.2% in September 2026, compared with 4.4% a year earlier.

Monthly change in payroll employment

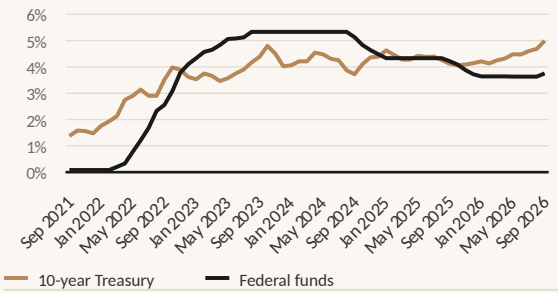
Thousands of jobs, seasonally adjusted. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics via FRED



Employers added 29,000 jobs in September, and the average over the past six months was 66,000.

10-year Treasury yield and federal funds rate

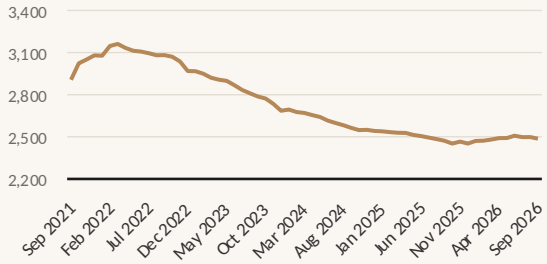
Monthly averages. Source: Federal Reserve via FRED and FRED



The 10-year yield averaged 4.99% in September, up from 4.12% a year earlier, while the federal funds rate averaged 3.75%.

Temporary help services employment

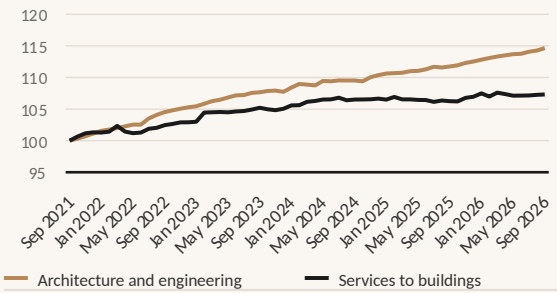
Thousands of employees, seasonally adjusted. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics via FRED



Temporary employment of 2.49 million is 21% below its March 2022 peak and slightly above its level a year earlier.

Engineering and building services employment

Index, September 2021 = 100. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics via FRED and FRED



Architecture and engineering employment is 14.6% above its September 2021 level, and building services employment is 7.3% above.

Each series runs from September 2021 to its latest month, September 2026, and GDP runs to the second quarter of 2026. Recent months are preliminary. FRED has no unemployment rate for October 2025, and the line bridges that month.

Select Market Participants

The listed reference companies in each sector, and the platforms, sponsors, and strategic buyers acquiring founder-owned businesses.

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES

LISTED COMPANIES

- Cintas
- ABM Industries
- Rollins
- APi Group
- BrightView
- FirstService
- Mistras Group
- SGS
- Bureau Veritas
- Intertek
- Eurofins Scientific
- UL Solutions

FIRE, SECURITY AND GUARDING

Pye-Barker Fire & Safety | AI Fire | Sciens Building Solutions | Allied Universal

FACILITY AND OFFICE TECHNOLOGY

4M Building Solutions | Landscape Workshop | DEX Imaging | UBEO Business Services | Pacific Office Automation

TESTING AND INSPECTION

Phenna Group | Transcat | EQT

MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES

LISTED COMPANIES

- Dentsu Group
- Advantage Solutions
- Publicis Groupe
- Stagwell
- WPP
- Omnicom
- Accenture
- Cognizant
- 4imprint
- Daktronics

AGENCY PLATFORMS AND SPONSORS

OneMagnify (Crestview) | Power Digital | Wpromote (ZMC) | Supreme Group (Trinity Hunt) | OuterBox (WILsquare) | Impact XM (Riverside) | Platinum Equity

PROMOTIONAL PRODUCTS

HALO Branded Solutions | IdentiBrands (Proforma) | Zebra Marketing

CONSULTING

Armanino | Wavestone

ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING

LISTED COMPANIES

- AECOM
- Jacobs
- Tetra Tech
- Stantec
- Bowman Consulting
- Willdan Group
- TIC Solutions
- WSP Global

PLATFORMS AND CONSOLIDATORS

Bernhard Capital Partners | Ardurra (Littlejohn & Co.) | Salas O'Brien | SAM Companies | Pape-Dawson | PRIME AE Group | GHK Capital Partners | Control Point Associates | Blew & Associates

FORENSIC ENGINEERING

J.S. Held

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES

LISTED COMPANIES

- Brown & Brown
- Crawford & Company
- WTW
- Ryan Specialty
- Aon
- Arthur J. Gallagher
- Marsh McLennan
- The Baldwin Group

INSURANCE BROKERAGE

Inszone Insurance Services | World Insurance Associates | EPIC Insurance Brokers & Consultants | King Risk Partners | Risk Placement Services

WEALTH AND OTHER

Hightower | Mercer Advisors | Class Valuation | Broadridge

STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

LISTED COMPANIES

- AMN Healthcare
- Korn Ferry
- Randstad
- Barrett Business Services
- TriNet
- Kforce
- ManpowerGroup
- TrueBlue
- Robert Half
- Insperity

STAFFING FIRMS

Aerotek (Allegis) | ALKU | CHG Healthcare | Airswift | VeriWorks | HW Staffing Solutions | CTI Staffing | Care Career | Empire Workforce Solutions

INVESTORS

Concord Holdings | Red Dog Equity

Private participants are buyers in transactions announced between October 2025 and October 2026. The list is illustrative. Company names are the property of their owners and are shown for identification.

03

Connect With Us

- Start a conversation
- Our team
- Benchmark International
- Disclosures and sources



Connect With Us

A first conversation is confidential and carries no obligation.

CONFIDENTIAL. NO PRESSURE. NO COMMITMENTS.

It all starts with a conversation.

Our first step is always a confidential conversation exploring your goals, your company, and your options. We welcome calls from owners considering a strategic sale, merger, or change-of-control transaction in any of our five industries, and from the accountants, attorneys, and wealth advisors who work with them.

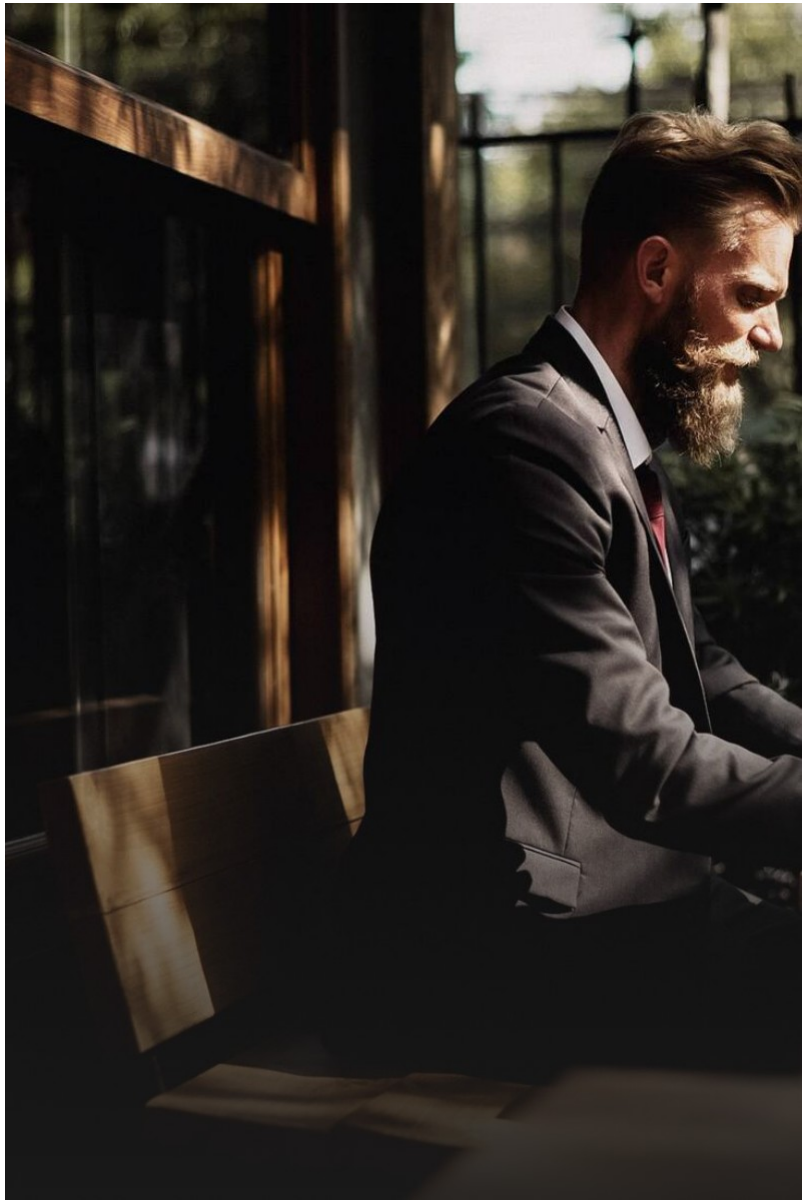


Jared Hardin

MANAGING DIRECTOR

813-771-6675

j.hardin@benchmarkintl.com



SCHEDULE A CONVERSATION

READ THE REPORT ONLINE

Our Team

The Middle Market team leads each engagement from the first conversation through signing and closing.

Middle Market

The team represents owners of privately held companies with $50 million to $500 million of total enterprise value on strategic sales, mergers, and qualifying change-of-control transactions.

HEADQUARTERS

AMERICAS
4030 West Boy Scout Blvd.
Suite 500, Tampa, FL 33607
+1 813 898 2350

EUROPE
One New Bailey, 4 Stanley St.
Manchester, M3 5JL
+44 (0) 161 359 4400

AFRICA
Airport Office Park, Freight Rd.
Cape Town Airport, 7525
+27 (0) 21 300 2055



Jordan Houtz
MANAGING DIRECTOR
HEAD OF MIDDLE MARKET
813-771-6675
jhoutz@benchmarkintl.com



Jared Hardin
MANAGING DIRECTOR
813-771-6675
j.hardin@benchmarkintl.com



Alex Zykov
TRANSACTION DIRECTOR



Shannon Hess
CLIENT ENGAGEMENT DIRECTOR



Sunny Garten
Senior Deal Associate



Michael Wynn
Senior Deal Associate



Jason Lisiak, CFA
Research Associate



Alexandra Barr
Transaction Support Associate



Josiah Warren
Transaction Support Associate



Luke Ernst
Deal Analyst

BUSINESS SERVICES COVERAGE

- Commercial & Facility Services
- Financial & Insurance Services
- Marketing, Sales & Technology-Enabled Services
- Staffing & Human Capital
- Engineering, Architecture & Consulting

Team as listed on the Middle Market site in October 2026.

Benchmark International

The world's leading privately owned sell-side M&A advisor, with its Middle Market team focused on five industries.

BENCHMARK® INTERNATIONAL

The Middle Market team is the part of Benchmark International that advises owners of privately held companies across five industries on strategic sales, mergers, and qualifying change-of-control transactions.

#1

Privately owned sell-side M&A advisor worldwide, based on PitchBook's Q2 2026 Global League Tables

$50M to $500M

Total enterprise value range that the Middle Market team serves

5

Focused industry groups with dedicated expertise

15

Global offices across the Americas, Europe, and Africa

RECOGNITION

THE M&A ADVISOR — INVESTMENT BANKING FIRM OF THE YEAR

PitchBook — #1 SELL-SIDE EXCLUSIVE M&A ADVISOR IN THE WORLD

LSEG — #1 PRIVATELY-HELD M&A ADVISORS WORLDWIDE

DealMakers — MERGERS & ACQUISITIONS (UNLISTED DEALS) FIRST IN THE CATEGORY OF INVESTMENT ADVISERS (DEAL FLOW)

FIVE INDUSTRY GROUPS

- INDUSTRIALS
- **BUSINESS SERVICES**
- CONSUMER
- HEALTHCARE
- TECHNOLOGY

Ranking based on PitchBook's Q2 2026 Global League Tables, as published at benchmarkintl.com. Awards as shown on the Middle Market site.

Important Disclosures

Please read these notes together with the brief.

"Benchmark International" refers to the Benchmark International group of companies, which provide merger and acquisition advisory services to business owners through offices around the world. The Middle Market team is part of Benchmark International. Any reference to Benchmark International in this material includes its affiliated companies, as the context requires.

Benchmark International and its affiliates may have had, may currently have, or may in the future have business relationships with companies named in this material, with potential parties to a transaction and their related persons, or with their competitors, customers, or suppliers. When Benchmark International is engaged to provide advisory services in a transaction, it acts only for its client in connection with that transaction.

The distribution of this material in certain jurisdictions may be restricted by law, and accordingly, recipients of this material represent that they are able to receive it without contravention of any registration requirement or other legal restrictions in the jurisdictions in which they reside or in which they conduct business.

This material does not contain all the information needed to assess any transaction. You must conduct your own investigations and analyses. Benchmark International does not provide valuations, appraisals, or fairness opinions, and does not provide accounting, tax, investment, regulatory, or legal advice to anyone. This material is for discussion and informational purposes only and is not a recommendation, offer, or solicitation for the purchase or sale of any security or an invitation or inducement to engage in any transaction or investment activity. Benchmark International obtained the information in this material from public filings, company announcements, published reports, and other third-party sources, together with its own transaction experience. Benchmark International has not independently verified such information, the information is current only as of the date stated, and no obligation is undertaken to provide updated or additional information. Transaction values, multiples, and other figures are as publicly reported, and the price of any private company depends on that business. No representation or warranty, expressed or implied, is made in relation to the fairness, accuracy, correctness, or completeness of the information, opinions, or conclusions expressed herein. All forward-looking statements herein involve assumptions and elements of subjective judgment and analysis and are not facts. Past transactions are not indicative of future results, and nothing in this material guarantees future results or performance.

Company names, logos, and trademarks referenced in this material are the property of their respective owners and are used for identification only. Their use does not imply any affiliation with or endorsement by those owners.

This material is only being distributed to, and only made available to, and directed at: (a) persons who are outside the United Kingdom; (b) persons in the United Kingdom who have professional experience in matters relating to investments falling within Article 19(5) of the UK Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005, as amended (the "Order"); (c) high net worth entities and other persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be communicated falling within Article 49(2)(a) to (d) of the Order; or (d) any other person to whom this material may otherwise lawfully be communicated or caused to be communicated (all such persons in (b) to (d) together being referred to as "Relevant Persons"). This material must not be acted on or relied on by persons in the United Kingdom who are not Relevant Persons. In the United Kingdom, any investment or investment activity to which this material relates is only available to, and will be engaged with, Relevant Persons.

Information as of October 7, 2026.

Benchmark International | 4030 West Boy Scout Blvd., Suite 500, Tampa, FL 33607 | +1 813 898 2350 | benchmarkintl.com

Sources

The sources linked on each page, listed by page with the link text used.

KEY TRENDS IN BUSINESS SERVICES

Pye-Barker; APi Group; Federal Reserve; FRED series GS10; GF Data via ACG; ACEC; Bowman; Insurance Journal; Insurance Journal, September 21; Staffing Industry Analysts; FRED series TEMPHELPS; MediaPost; Marketing Dive; IBBA and M&A Source; IBBA and M&A Source release

PERSPECTIVES ON FIVE SECTORS

SDM; SGS; IAB and PwC; ASI; ENR; PSMJ; Risk & Insurance; WealthManagement.com; ASA; Staffing Industry Analysts

WHAT WE'RE READING

ACEC Research Institute; Staffing Industry Analysts; Insurance Journal; PitchBook; Reuters; GF Data via ACG; Federal Reserve; survey release; IBBA and M&A Source

FEATURE: FIRE AND LIFE SAFETY

Pye-Barker; Security Systems News; APi Group; APi Group, December 10, 2025; SDM; StockAnalysis; Union AlarmTronic; Suppression Systems, Inc.; Aegis Protective Services and Admiral Security Services; Southern Fire Control

CLIENT SPOTLIGHT: THREE FIRE AND LIFE SAFETY SALES

Cintas annual report

SELECT RECENT BUSINESS SERVICES M&A TRANSACTIONS

Pye-Barker; ASI; ASI Central; Bowman results; Bowman; Insurance Business; Insurance Journal; Staffing Industry Analysts; SIA forecast; Korn Ferry

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL'S BUSINESS SERVICES TRANSACTIONS

Benchmark International

PUBLIC COMPANIES: VALUATION

GF Data via ACG; IBBA and M&A Source; StockAnalysis

PUBLIC COMPANIES: OPERATING AND VALUATION METRICS

StockAnalysis

EARNINGS AND COMMENTARY

Willdan Group; Bowman Consulting; APi Group; TrueBlue; Stantec; Stagwell; ManpowerGroup; Ryan Specialty; Daktronics; Korn Ferry; Accenture; UL Solutions; Kforce; ABM Industries; FirstService; Advantage Solutions; BrightView; Crawford & Company; Robert Half; Tetra Tech

ECONOMIC TRENDS

FRED series A191RL1Q225SBEA; FRED series UNRATE; FRED series PAYEMS; FRED series GS10; FRED series FEDFUNDS; FRED series TEMPHELPS; FRED series CES6054130001; FRED series CES6056170001

SELECT MARKET PARTICIPANTS

StockAnalysis

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

benchmarkintl.com

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL RECORDS

Transaction records and the engagement portfolio as of October 1, 2026; announced transactions as published at benchmarkintl.com/insights, each linked from its card or tile.

Subscription sources that would add depth are listed in a separate one-page document.